

► **IT IS AN** interesting time in India's history. The country has a woman President, a woman Finance Minister and a woman chairing capital markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi). Parliament has ushered in one-third reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies. Indian women are literally over the moon, having played a significant role in Chandrayaan-3, India's successful lunar mission.

The country has also made progress in the realm of business. For instance in mid-market businesses, with 36 per cent of women in leadership roles, India is ahead of the current global (32 per cent), BRIC (34 per cent) and G7 (30 per cent) averages, according to Grant Thornton's International Business Report on 'Women in Business 2023 - The push for parity'. But a lot more needs to be done. Consider this: Six in 10 companies have less than 20 per cent representation of women in leadership (CXO and board) positions, per consult-

ing firm Aon's latest DEI Landscape Report. Half of these firms have less than 5 per cent representation.

"Overall, corporate India has progressed on women's representation at the leadership level over the past 10 years to 26-27 per cent. But what we are really gunning for is 50 per cent," says Sujatha Shivsankar, Chief-Culture, People Experience, IDE, Performance & Talent, KPMG in India. Referring to recent studies, Preetha Reddy, Vice Chairperson of Apollo Hospitals Enterprise, says women's representation is still skewed towards junior and middle management in 70 per cent of organisations in India. "This illustrates a clear need to enhance and augment the focus towards building a talent pool of senior women leaders, and preparing them for board positions and important committees."

As *Business Today* celebrates the 20th edition of the Most Powerful Women in Business (MPW), chronicling those that have made a difference to their organisations

between October 2022 and September 2023, it is imperative to find out what hampers a woman's ascension from junior levels.

What is worrying is that the career progression is poor even in sectors such as IT and banking, which have the largest female white-collar workforce in India. A study by CFA Institute—a global association of investment professionals—analysing the FY22 BRSR disclosures of 134 Indian companies showed that the IT sector suffers the widest chasm of 18.7 percentage points between women's representation at the employee level and at the level of key management personnel (KMP). Sindhu Gangadharan, SVP & MD of SAP Labs India and Head-SAP User Enablement, points out that India produces the world's highest number of female science, technology, engineering, and math (STEM) graduates every year, but only a third make it to a STEM career and even fewer continue after five years into their careers. "Every year, we lose brilliant mid-career women technolo-

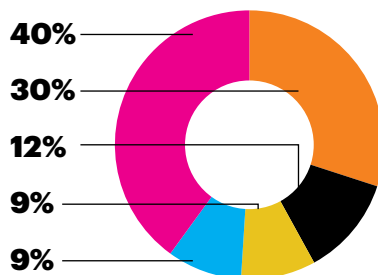
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UPHILL BATTLE

● While there is a higher proportion of women at the lower management levels, it falls as they climb up the ladder; six in 10 firms have less than 20 per cent women in leadership roles

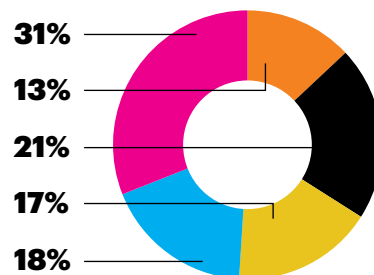
● About 30-35 per cent firms have less than 10 per cent representation at the senior management level

LEADERSHIP (CXO & BOARD)



● <5% ● 5-10% ● 10-15% ● 15-20% ● >20%

SENIOR MANAGEMENT



FEMALE REPRESENTATION AS A PERCENTAGE OF THE WORKFORCE;
SOURCE AON DEI LANDSCAPE REPORT, JUNE 2023